Using Cluster Analysis to Create Data-Driven Cultural Participation Profiles for Readers and Non-Readers in Germany

Lehmann, Marina
marina.lehmann@uni-mainz.de
Johannes Gutenberg-Universität Mainz, Germany

The analysis of readers and their reading and buying behavior is at the core of academic as well as non-academic reading and book market research. However, non-readers are often excluded from surveys or treated as a homogeneous entity. The number of analphabets in Germany is about 12% (Buddeberg / Grotlüschen 2020), but not every non-reader[1] lacks the ability to read. Some non-readers do have reading skills but decide not to pursue reading as a leisure activity. Their reasons are probably as diverse as the group of non-readers themselves. The book industry usually focuses on offering more reading material to its existing customers, and the number of annual new publications in Germany of 67,500 copies in 2023 (Börsenverein 2024) shows that it is successfully doing so.

Non-readers, however, are rarely considered as a potential new target group. When the German book market faced a decline of 6,4 million book buyers from 2013 to 2017 (Börsenverein 2018a), the study "Book Buyer – Quo Vadis?" rather focused on so-called "Abwanderer" (people who used to buy books but do not anymore) instead of exploring non-readers as potential buyers (Börsenverein 2018b). Overall, a profound scientific examination of non-readers and their (maybe underestimated) potential for becoming readers and book buyers is still missing.

How could we then explore non-readers as new potential readers and ultimately book buyers? This early-stage PhD project follows the idea that the cultural participation[2] behavior of non-readers could be key to this question. Most likely, there are groups of non-readers who have been participating in cultural activities, albeit in other contexts. Therefore, there might be ways of introducing this group of people to books and reading through their alternative leisure activities.

This work aims to lay the foundation for further research in this direction by developing data-driven cultural participation profiles to classify people according to their cultural leisure activities. It uses data collected within a sociological panel study surveying a representative cross section of German citizens (15 years or older, n=2952) on their cultural participation behavior in different cultural areas: literature, film, music, performing arts, visual arts, cultural production and cultural education (Otte et al. n.d.). In total, the profiles are built on 83 variables from these areas. They cover attitude as well as usage variables. Factor analysis serves as a method for dimensionality reduction. For cluster analysis, a combination of k-means and hierarchical clustering will be used. Variation in the resulting clusters will be accounted for by a systematic comparison of different clusters to assure robust results.

In applied social research and marketing research clustering is a widespread and useful technique to gain insight into the behavior of different social groups – e.g. the German milieu model Sinus Milieus by Sinus-Institute (Sinus 2024) or the media usage typology Digital Media Types by ARD/ZDF (DMT n.d.). The basic idea of this PhD project is to transfer this concept to reading and book market research by making use of cultural participation profiles to investigate differences in the behavior of readers and non-readers. The first – and currently ongoing – step towards this goal is to establish the profiles through cluster analysis. The second step will be to do statistical analyses on the subgroups of readers and non-readers. Their profiles will be compared and correlated with further sociodemographic characteristics as well as data on reading socialization to get a more diverse picture of non-readers. Finally, the third step explores how the results of the analysis can be used to promote reading, foster cultural participation and improve target group analysis in book marketing.

Notes

1. Non-readers are defined as "literate people for whom the leisure activity ›reading‹ [...] tends towards zero" (Groeben / Scheele 1975).
2. Cultural Participation as defined by Otte includes the reception, consumption and production of cultural goods as well as cultural education (Otte 2022).

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